



IRONY

When what happens is the opposite of what's expected

1 What is it?

Irony (EYE-run-ee)

Irony is when there's a contrast between what is expected (or what is said) and what actually happens or is meant — often creating humour, tension or a pointed message.

expectation + the opposite actually happens

2 See it in action

Situational

"A fire station burns down."

Verbal

"'Lovely weather,' she said, soaked in the pouring rain."

Dramatic

"The audience knows the killer is hiding in the room — the character doesn't."

Everyday

"The traffic police officer got a parking ticket."



Quick reminder!

Try telling the difference between something ironic and something that's just bad luck — it's trickier than it sounds.

3 More to know

Situational

"A locksmith gets locked out of their own house."

Verbal (sarcasm)

"'Nice job,' he said, watching the vase smash on the floor."

FUN FACT

Alanis Morissette's 1996 song "Ironic" is famous for listing examples (like "rain on your wedding day") that many critics and English teachers argue aren't actually ironic at all — just unfortunate coincidences, sparking decades of debate about what irony really means.

4 Why it's used

Irony helps: create humour, highlight a bigger truth, build tension, or make a sharp critical point — often more powerfully than saying something directly.

There are three main types: verbal (saying the opposite of what you mean), situational (an outcome that's the opposite of what's expected), and dramatic (the audience knows something a character doesn't).



Keep going!

Dramatic irony is everywhere in films — watch for a moment where you know something the character on screen doesn't.

5 Where you'll spot it

Verbal irony

Saying the opposite of what you actually mean, often sarcastically: "Great, just what I needed" after something goes wrong.

Dramatic irony

The audience or reader knows something a character in the story doesn't — used constantly in thrillers and tragedies.

⚠ Watch out!

Irony is often confused with simple coincidence or bad luck — a wedding ruined by rain isn't automatically ironic, unless there's a specific twist of expectation (like a rainmaker's wedding being rained out).

6 Quick recap

Opposite of expected

Verbal, situational, dramatic

Can build humour or tension



You got this!

Sarcasm is a common everyday form of verbal irony — saying 'nice one' after someone drops their lunch tray is a small, real example.